

Designing for Neurodiversity

Sarah Massengale

Marcelo Paiva

Our hosts



Sarah Massengale

Certified Accessibility Specialist

Open to work and contract opportunities



Marcelo Paiva

Head UX and Accessibility, ClearCompany

Creator of WCAG plugin for Figma

Sarah's positionality on Accessibility:



I'm a blind, queer, neurodivergent white woman, and my identities deeply influence my approach to inclusive design.

My advocacy extends beyond work, as I live the inequities I fight against every day.

I challenge 'best practices' often created by non-disabled, straight, white people, to ensure digital experiences are accessible and equitable for all.

Marcelo's positionality on Accessibility:



As a diabetic, hard-of-hearing Brazilian immigrant in the U.S. since 1992, I've experienced exclusion firsthand. Navigating cultures, language barriers, and diverse roles has shaped my approach to inclusive design.

Aware of how my identity informs my perspective and privilege, I'm driven to create digital spaces that are truly welcoming and accessible for all.

Understanding our linguistic choices

Two types of language in the disabled community's lexicon:



Identity-first



Person-first
Our preference

Identity-First Language

Language that places the disability before the personhood.

This is only done by certain members of the disability community as a marker of disability pride and activism.

Typical usage: Only if you know the person you're interacting with prefers it.

Example, Sarah chooses to self-identify as a blind, neuro-divergent, queer woman. Someone knowing that and referring to her as a person who's blind will get quite the lecture on why they just insulted her.

Person-first language *(Our preference)*

Language that places emphasis on the person and not their disability

Typical usage: If preferred by the specific person with whom you are interacting, or in mass communication, training, or journalism settings

Example:

- *person who's blind; a user who relies on assistive technologies*
- *person who's autistic; a user who perceives information differently*

Have you ever felt any of these emotions?

Anxious

Depressed

Overwhelmed

Grief

Panicked

Lonely

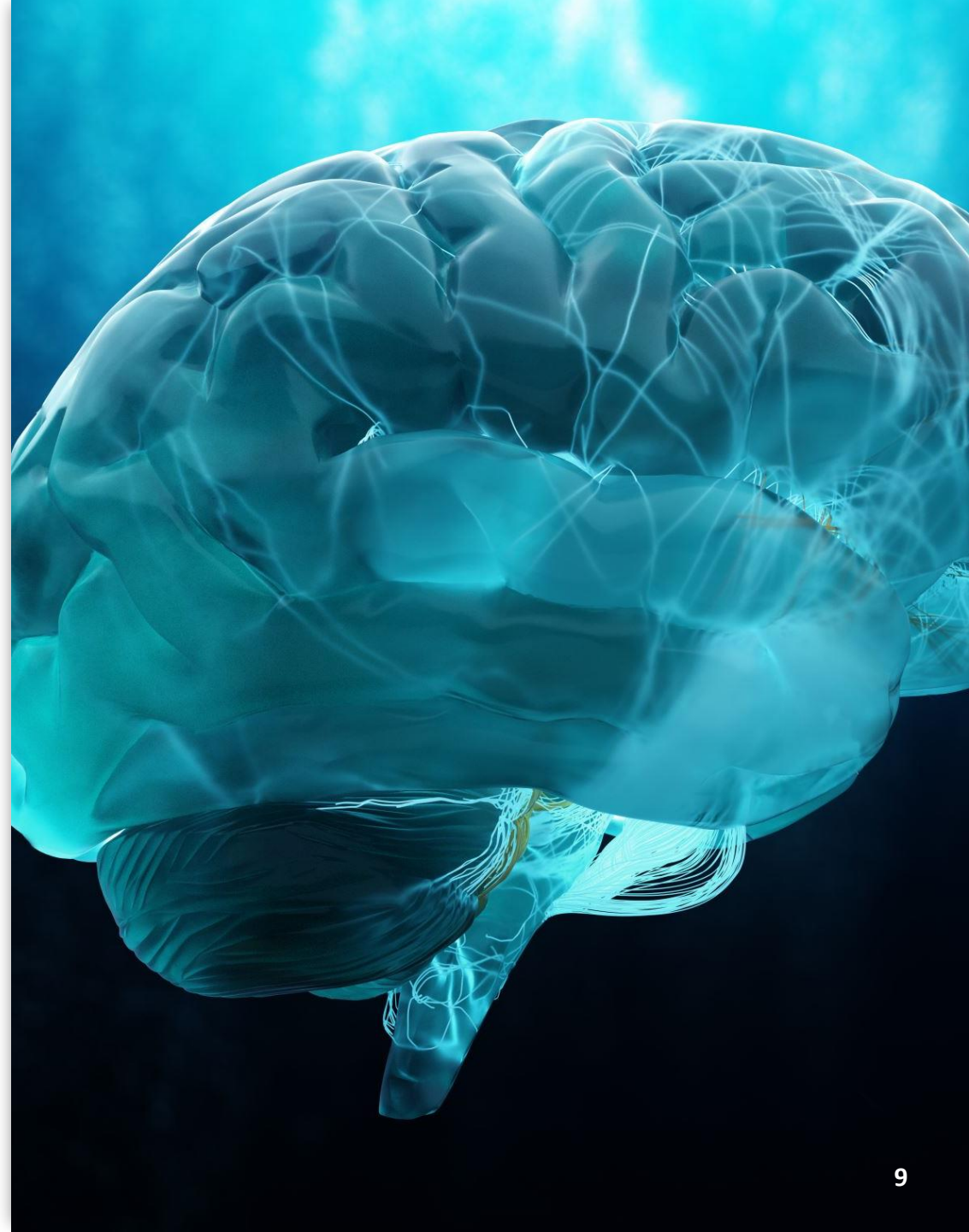
Angry

Hungry



Neurodiversity

Natural variations in brain function and cognition, leading to different ways of thinking, learning, and processing information.



Neurodivergence is not a limitation

it's simply a different way of perceiving
and experiencing the world.



At some point in life, we all encounter moments when we need information presented differently.

Whether it's due to stress, grief, exhaustion, or environmental distractions, our ability to process information fluctuates.

Common Neurodivergent perceptions in UX Design

Prefers predictable patterns, reduced sensory overload, and clear structure.

Struggles with focus, distractions, and complex navigation.

Discover endless outdoor styles just right for you →

Registry | Wayfair Credit Card | FREE Shipping Over \$35*

Menu



Find anything home...



Cart

Furniture Outdoor Bedding & Bath Rugs Décor & Pillows Organization Lighting Kitchen Baby & Kids Renovation Appliances Pet Sale

Outdoor & Patio Furniture →

Outdoor Lounge Chairs
Patio Dining Sets
Adirondack Chairs
Outdoor Seating & Patio Chairs
Patio Rocking Chairs & Gliders
Porch Swings
Hammocks
Patio Conversation Sets
Patio Bar Furniture

Outdoor Cooking & Tabletop →

Gas Grills
Charcoal Grills
Outdoor Kitchens

Outdoor Shades →

Gazebos
Outdoor Umbrellas
Pergolas
Canopies

Outdoor Décor →

Outdoor Rugs
Statues & Sculptures
Outdoor Pillows & Cushions
Mailboxes
Bird Baths

Garden →

Planters
Trellises
Greenhouses

Hot Tubs & Saunas →

Backyard Play →

Trampolines
Swing Sets
Sandboxes
Outdoor Games

Outdoor Heating & Cooling →

Firepits
Chimineas

Garage & Outdoor Organization →

Sheds
Deck Boxes & Patio Storage

Outdoor Fencing

Shop by Material

Wicker Patio Furniture
Metal Patio Furniture
Wood Patio Furniture
Teak Patio Furniture

Featured Shops

Sunbrella Performance Fabrics

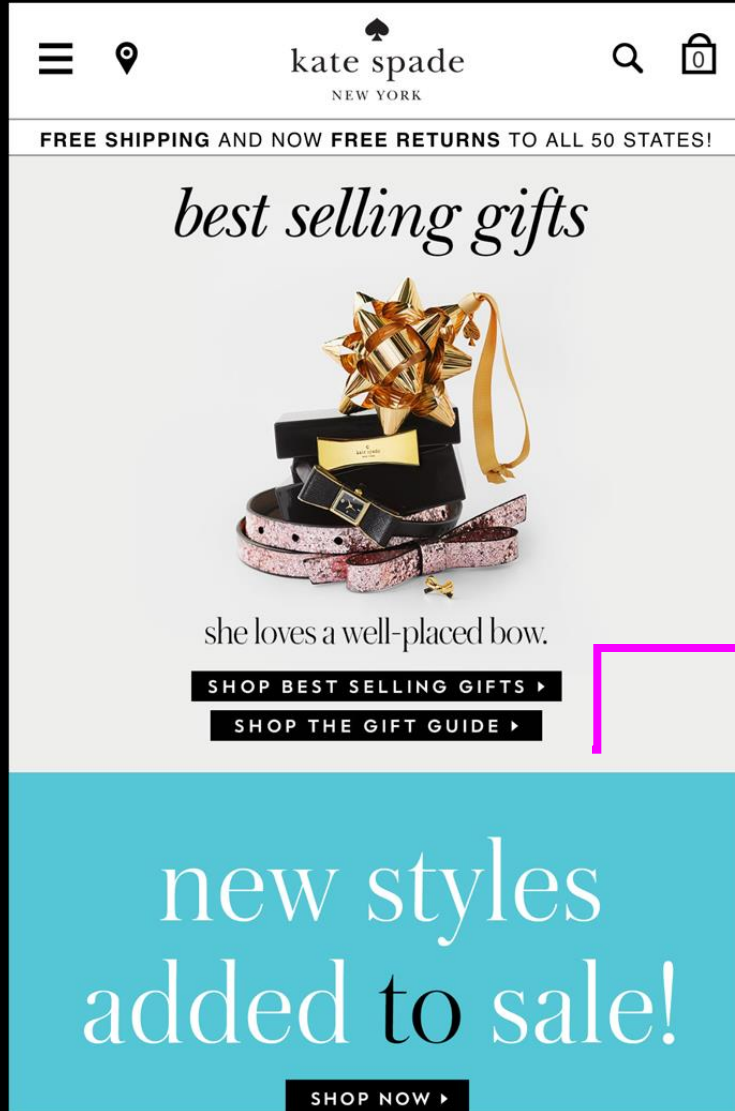
Project Help

Design Your Outdoor Space

Wayfair Deals

Outdoor Sale

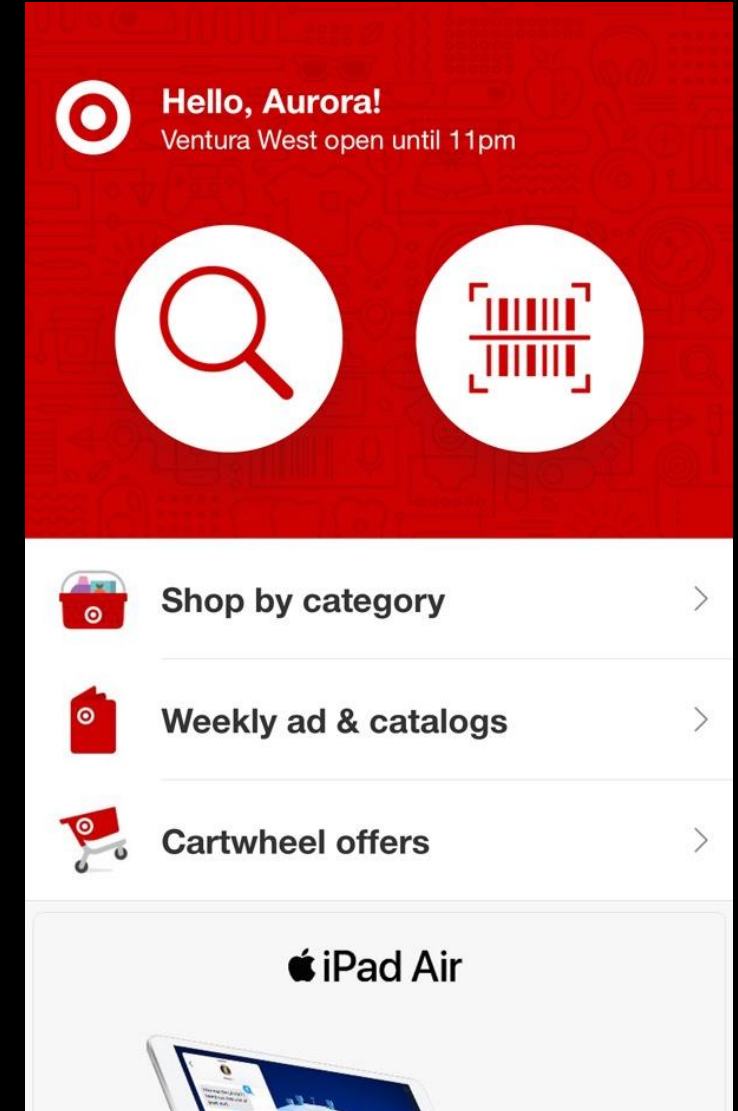
Finds hard to tap small buttons, tiny target areas (1 of 3)



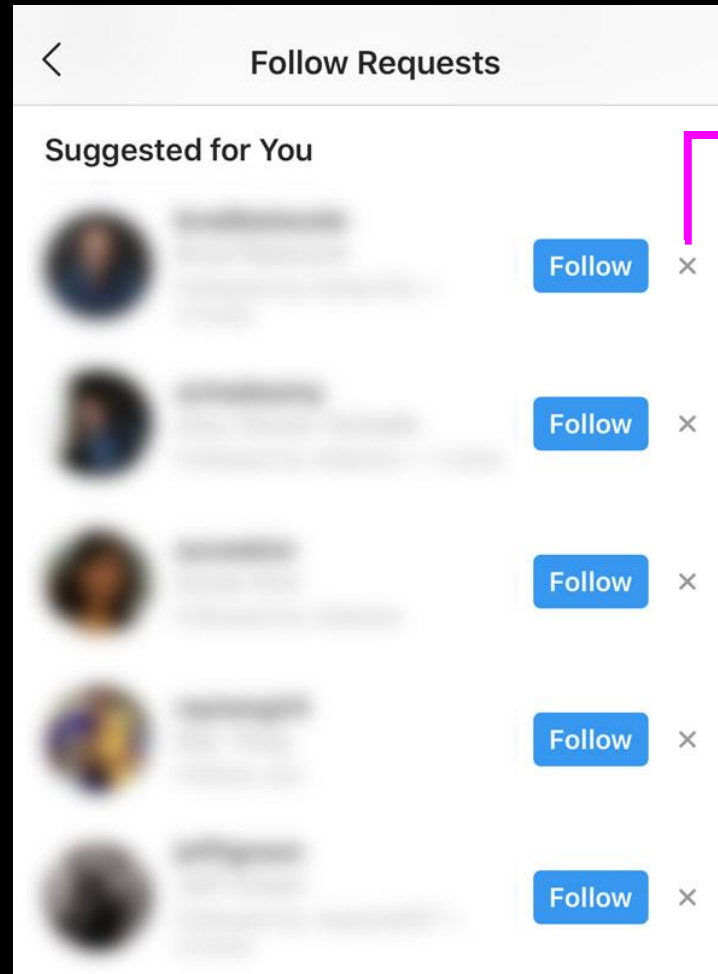
Bad example



Good example



Finds hard to tap small buttons, tiny target areas (2 of 3)



Opposite action to close

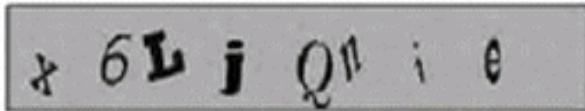
Finds hard to tap small buttons, tiny target areas (3 of 3)



Tiny target area



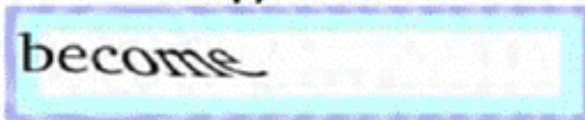
Aversion to CAPTCHA, perceiving numbers, understanding graphs.



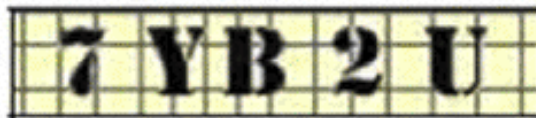
AltaVista Website CAPTCHA



Gimpy CAPTCHA



EZ-Gimpy CAPTCHA



PayPal Website CAPTCHA



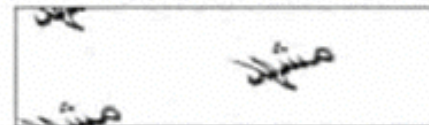
Yahoo Website and Chat CAPTCHA



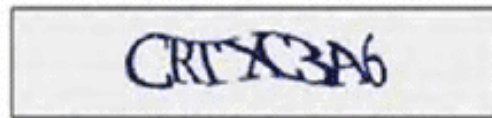
reCAPTCHA



Baffle Text CAPTCHA



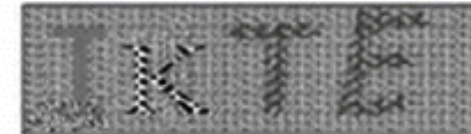
Persian/Arabic CAPTCHA



Hotmail Website CAPTCHA



Handwritten Word based CAPTCHA



HVS Masking Characteristic CAPTCHA



Question Based CAPTCHA



YouTube Website CAPTCHA

CAPTCHA - Completely Automated Public Turing test to tell Computers and Humans Apart.

Math and Puzzle CAPTCHA

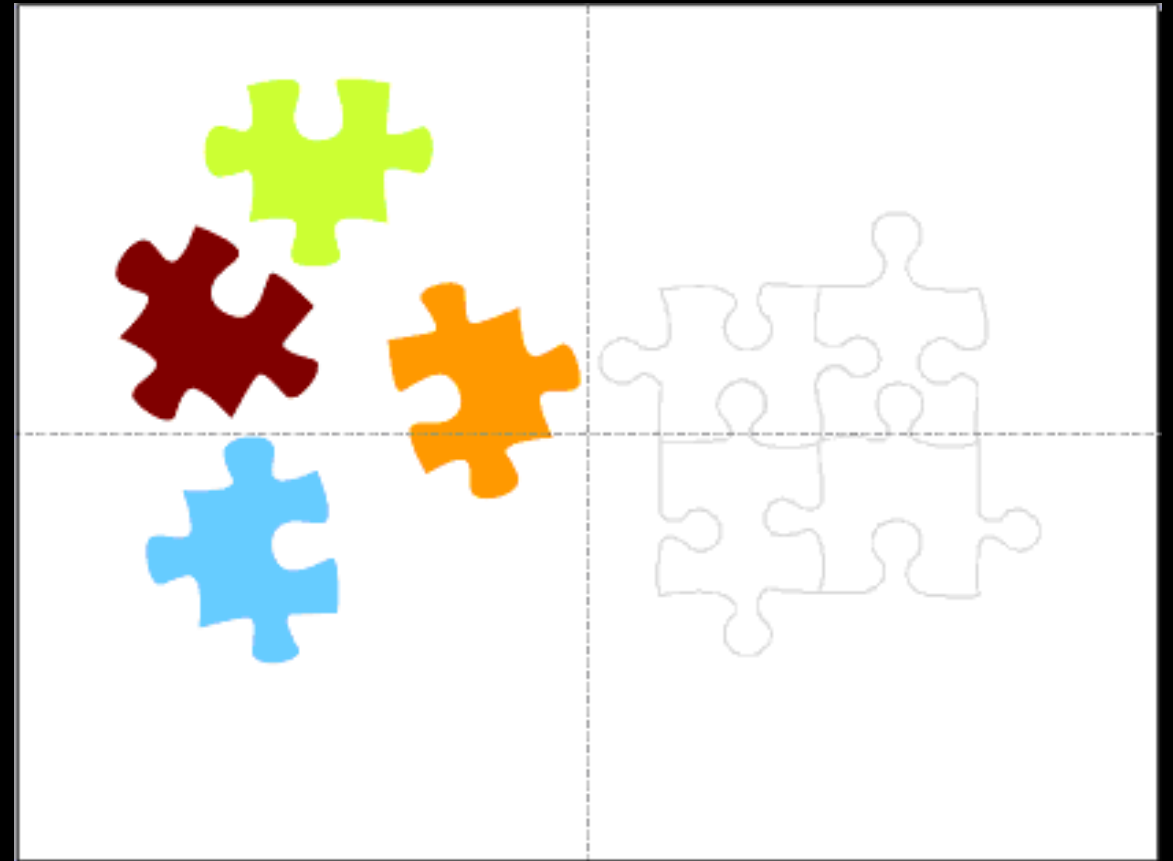
Example using a mathematical CAPTCHA.



Submit Form



Enter Code*:



Becomes overwhelmed with cluttered interfaces.

The screenshot displays the Jira Core Project Kanban board. The top navigation bar includes the Jira logo, 'Dashboards', 'Projects', 'Issues', 'DbConsole', and a 'Create' button. A search bar and utility icons are on the right. The board is titled 'Core Project' and includes a 'Switch Boards' dropdown, user avatars, and a 'Labels' dropdown. Filter buttons at the top include 'Due This Week', 'Only My Issues', and 'Recently Updated'. The board is organized into columns representing workflow stages: OPEN (5 items), IN PROGRESS (10 items), UNDER REVIEW (12 items), DONE (8 items), CANCELLED (3 items), and REJECTED (2 items). A vertical bar between 'UNDER REVIEW' and 'DONE' indicates '10 APPROVED' items. Each card in the board shows the item name, a summary of time spent and remaining estimate, a status indicator (checkmark), a category code (CP-XX), and a user avatar. Some cards also show a date (e.g., '12 NOV', '03 NOV', '05 NOV').

Stage	Count	Item Name	Time Spent	Remaining Estimate	Status	Category	User	Notes
OPEN	5	Handmade Wooden Cheese	None	None	✓	CP-46	[Avatar]	
		Unbranded Concrete Pizza	None	None	✓	CP-47		
		Practical Cotton Chair	None	None	✓	CP-48		
		Fantastic Granite Bacon	None	None	✓	CP-49		
		Tasty Frozen Keyboard	None	None	✓	CP-50		
IN PROGRESS	10	Intelligent Fresh Tuna	None	None	✓	CP-39	[Avatar]	12 NOV
		Licensed Rubber Soap	None	None	✓	CP-37		
		Incredible Soft Chair	None	None	✓	CP-36		
		Licensed Granite Ball	None	None	✓	CP-15		
		Tasty Frozen Gloves	None	None	✓			
UNDER REVIEW	12	Handcrafted Fresh Pants	None	None	✓	CP-42	[Avatar]	ready-for-dev, 03 NOV
		Handcrafted Cotton Fish	None	None	✓	CP-43	[Avatar]	
		Handmade Metal Fish	None	None	✓	CP-44	[Avatar]	05 NOV
		Sleek Concrete Ball	None	None	✓	CP-30	[Avatar]	
DONE	8	Licensed Steel Soap	None	None	✓	CP-21		
		Generic Metal Towels	None	None	✓	CP-25		
		Awesome Fresh Pizza	None	None	✓	CP-26		
		Unbranded Concrete Bike	None	None	✓	CP-27		
		Ergonomic Cotton Shoes	None	None	✓	CP-16		
CANCELLED	3	Gorgeous Wooden Tuna	None	None	✓	CP-41	[Avatar]	
		Fantastic Concrete Bacon	None	None	✓	CP-45	[Avatar]	
REJECTED	2	Incredible Wooden Car	None	None	✓	CP-40		
		Rustic Soft Car	None	None	✓	CP-28		

Becomes overwhelmed with cluttered interfaces (1 of 2)

FOREVER 21

WOMEN + ACC

MEN

PLUS + CURVE

GIRLS

BEAUTY BY  RILEY ROSE

SALE

 Search Products 

LAST CHANCE! FLASH SALE: UP TO 50% OFF
SHOP NOW [Details](#)

RECEIVE 15% OFF YOUR FIRST IN-APP PURCHASE OF \$60+
DOWNLOAD APP [Details](#)

Home / [Terms & Conditions](#)

HELP

FAQ

Contact Us

Order Status

Online Return & Exchange

Store Return & Exchange

Shipping Info

Payment & Prices

Gift & E-Gift Card

Size Guide

Privacy Center

Your California Privacy Rights

[Terms & Conditions](#)

Refer-A-Friend Program Terms

Pick-Up In Store

Web Accessibility Statement

TERMS OF USE

Effective as of January 16, 2018

These Terms of Use (“**Terms**”) apply to the website located at forever21.com, the Forever 21 mobile applications, and any other websites or applications associated with Forever 21 brands or products that direct the viewer or user to these Terms (collectively, the “**Site**”). In these Terms, the terms “Forever 21,” “we,” and “us” refers to Forever 21, Inc. and its respective subsidiaries and affiliated companies.

Your access to and use of the Sites is conditioned on your acceptance of and compliance with these Terms. These Terms apply to all visitors, users and others who access or use the Site. **By accessing or using the Site you agree to be bound by these Terms. If you disagree with any part of the Terms then you should discontinue access or use of the Site.**

ARBITRATION NOTICE: EXCEPT IF YOU OPT-OUT AND EXCEPT FOR CERTAIN TYPES OF DISPUTES DESCRIBED IN THE ARBITRATION SECTION BELOW, YOU AGREE THAT DISPUTES BETWEEN YOU AND FOREVER 21 WILL BE RESOLVED BY BINDING, INDIVIDUAL ARBITRATION AND YOU WAIVE YOUR RIGHT TO PARTICIPATE IN A CLASS ACTION LAWSUIT OR CLASS-WIDE ARBITRATION.

ABILITY TO USE THE SITE

In order to accept the Terms and to use the Site, you must be at least 18 years of age (“Minimum Age”). The Site not intended for users under the Minimum Age. You hereby affirmatively represent that (a) you are at least the Minimum Age in the applicable country; (b) you have the consent of your parent(s) to use the Site if you are under 18 years of age; (c) you have all the applicable rights and authority to grant FOREVER 21 the rights granted in these Terms; and (d) you have read, understood, and agree to be bound by these Terms. If you are not at least the Minimum Age, do not have parental consent, or you do not agree to all the terms and conditions of these Terms, you may not use the Site.

USE RESTRICTIONS

You understand and accept that all information, data, text, software, music, sound, photographs, graphics, audio, video, message or other material appearing on this Site (collectively, “**Content**”) are owned by FOREVER 21 or its licensors. You are prohibited from using any Content on the Site without the express written consent of material contained on this Site or any other server. Any permission granted under these Terms terminates automatically without further notice if you breach any of the above terms. Upon such termination, you agree to immediately destroy any downloaded and/or printed materials. Any unauthorized use of any material contained on this Site may violate domestic and/or international copyright laws, the laws of privacy and publicity, and communications regulations and statutes.

ANY USE OF THE SERVICES NOT SPECIFICALLY PERMITTED UNDER THESE TERMS IS STRICTLY PROHIBITED.

CHANGE IN TERMS

We may from time to time change the terms that govern your use of our Site. We may change, move or delete portions of, or may add to, our Site from time to time. If we make material changes to the Terms, we will notify you by email or through a message posted on the Site. Your continued use of our Site following any such change constitutes your agreement and affirmative acceptance to follow and be bound by the modified Terms. If you do not agree to, or cannot comply with, the Terms as modified, you must stop using the Site.

SUBMISSION OF CONTENT; COMMENTS, IMAGES, VIDEOS AND OTHER CONTENT

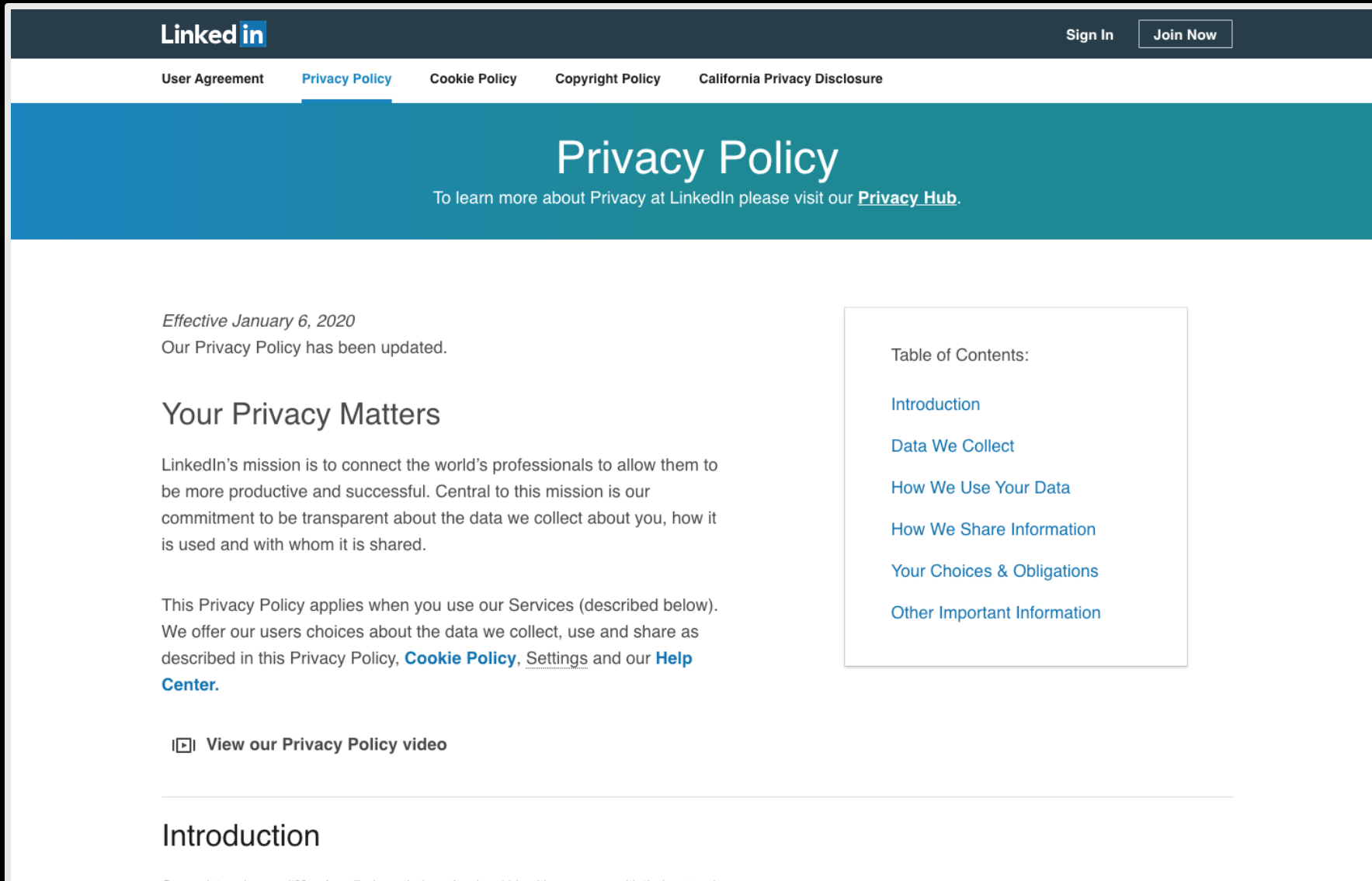
For any content you provide to FOREVER 21, on or by the Site, or otherwise disclose, submit or offer in connection with your use of this Site or other websites such as Facebook or Instagram that may interact with this Site, including comments, ideas, images, photographs, video clips, audio clips, graphics, tags, data, materials, information, and other submissions, including submissions with any hashtags such as #F21xME or #F21xMusic (collectively, ‘User Content’), you specifically grant us a non-exclusive, transferable, sub-licensable, royalty-free, fully paid up, worldwide license (but not the obligation) to use any User Content that you post on or in connection with FOREVER 21 (“IP License”). The IP License includes, for example and without limitations, the right and license to use, reproduce, modify, edit, adapt, publish, translate, create derivative works from, distribute, perform and display such material (in whole or part) worldwide and/or to incorporate it in other works in any form, media, or technology now known or later developed, in both digital and physical owned channels, and will not be limited in any way in its use or modifications to the submission, whether for commercial purposes or not, of the User Content. In certain circumstances FOREVER 21 may also share your contribution with trusted third parties. You are also granting us a non-exclusive, transferable, sub-licensable, royalty-free, fully paid up, worldwide license (but not the obligation) to use your name, likeness, personality, voice, or any other materials or information you provide to FOREVER 21 in connection with your content.

FOREVER 21 is not and shall not be under any obligation (1) to maintain any User Content in confidence; (2) to pay you any compensation for any User Content; (3) to credit or acknowledge you for User Content; or (4) to respond to any User Content.

You understand and agree that it is your obligation to make sure the User Content you submit to the Site must not violate the rights of any third party, including copyright, trademark, privacy and other intellectual or proprietary rights. You also understand and agree that User Content you submit to the Site must not be obscene, defamatory, libelous, abusive, harassing, threatening, obscene, fraudulent, or otherwise illegal.

Large blocks of text with no high-level summaries, like this example on Forever 21’s website, are often received poorly by users, dismissed as “for lawyers” or “for someone who knows what they’re looking for.”

Becomes overwhelmed with cluttered interfaces (2 of 2)



The screenshot shows the LinkedIn Privacy Policy page. At the top, there's a dark blue header with the LinkedIn logo on the left and 'Sign In' and 'Join Now' buttons on the right. Below this is a white navigation bar with links for 'User Agreement', 'Privacy Policy' (which is highlighted), 'Cookie Policy', 'Copyright Policy', and 'California Privacy Disclosure'. The main content area has a teal header with the title 'Privacy Policy' and a sub-header 'To learn more about Privacy at LinkedIn please visit our [Privacy Hub](#).' Below this, the page is divided into two columns. The left column contains the text 'Effective January 6, 2020' and 'Our Privacy Policy has been updated.' followed by a section titled 'Your Privacy Matters' with a paragraph about LinkedIn's mission and a paragraph about the scope of the policy. At the bottom of this column is a video player with the title 'View our Privacy Policy video'. The right column contains a 'Table of Contents' section with links to 'Introduction', 'Data We Collect', 'How We Use Your Data', 'How We Share Information', 'Your Choices & Obligations', and 'Other Important Information'.

LinkedIn

Sign In Join Now

User Agreement Privacy Policy Cookie Policy Copyright Policy California Privacy Disclosure

Privacy Policy

To learn more about Privacy at LinkedIn please visit our [Privacy Hub](#).

Effective January 6, 2020
Our Privacy Policy has been updated.

Your Privacy Matters

LinkedIn's mission is to connect the world's professionals to allow them to be more productive and successful. Central to this mission is our commitment to be transparent about the data we collect about you, how it is used and with whom it is shared.

This Privacy Policy applies when you use our Services (described below). We offer our users choices about the data we collect, use and share as described in this Privacy Policy, [Cookie Policy](#), [Settings](#) and our [Help Center](#).

 View our Privacy Policy video

Introduction

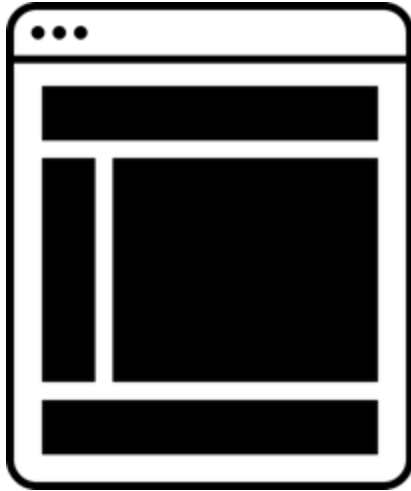
Table of Contents:

- [Introduction](#)
- [Data We Collect](#)
- [How We Use Your Data](#)
- [How We Share Information](#)
- [Your Choices & Obligations](#)
- [Other Important Information](#)

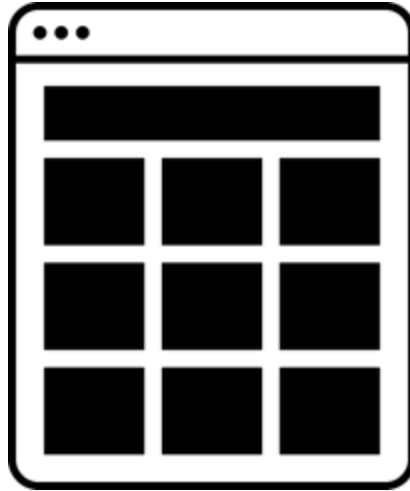
LinkedIn's legal policy does include some legal phrasing, it also includes a written, plain-language summary and link to a video summary, along with plain-language "translations" throughout the page.

This strategy avoids the overwhelming and complicated legalese with which most other policy disclosures lead.

Prefers predictable patterns, reduced sensory overload.



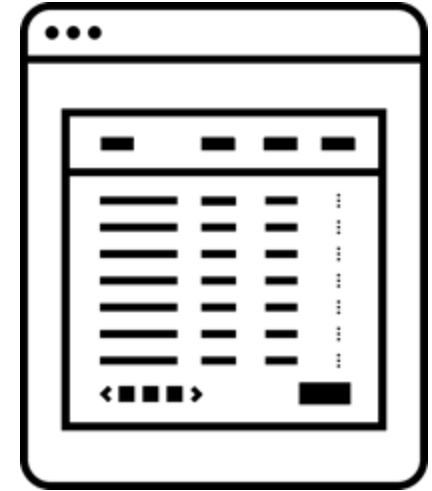
Predictable Regions



Navigable Articles



**Descriptive
Items**



**Consistent
Data Lists**

Understanding Neurodiversity Needs

It is essential to recognize that neurodiverse users, such as those with ADHD, autism, dyslexia, or anxiety, perceive and process information differently.

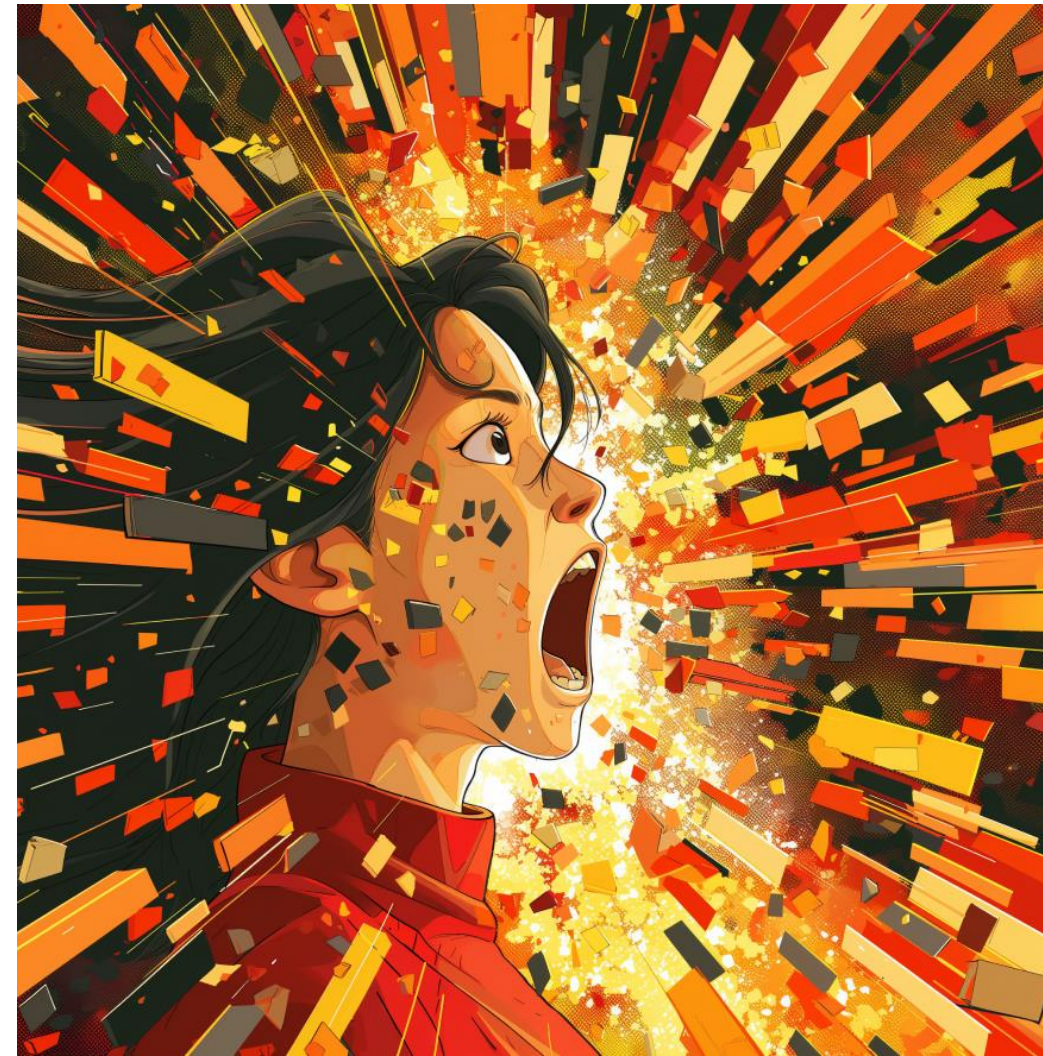
Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD/ADD):

May struggle with focus and attention, often feeling overwhelmed by too much information at once.

WCAG Quotes

“Why are they asking for all of this information? I just want to apply for the job!”

Neurodiverse perception: Overwhelm
Input Assistance WCAG 3.3.6 – Error Prevention



The illustration shows a frustrated character shouting, surrounded by an explosion of sticky notes, symbolizing the chaos and frustration of frequent information being requested.

How ADHD affects user interactions

Difficulty focusing, task switching, and overwhelming interfaces.

Long tasks cause distraction

Complex workflows without breaks make it hard to stay engaged.

Easily overwhelmed by clutter

Too much information at once can lead to frustration or task abandonment.

Interruptions break workflow

Unexpected pop-ups or notifications make it difficult to refocus.

A person with ADHD wants:

Simple, distraction-free interactions with clear guidance.

Step-by-step tasks

Breaking tasks into small steps helps maintain focus and reduces overwhelm.

WCAG 2.4.6
Headings and Labels

Minimal distractions

Reducing pop-ups and clutter helps users stay engaged and complete tasks.

WCAG 2.2.2
Pause, Stop, Hide

Flexible time limits

Avoiding strict deadlines allows users to work at their own pace.

WCAG 2.2.1
Timing Adjustable

Autosave and undo options

Prevents loss of progress and reduces frustration from mistakes.

WCAG 3.3.6
Error Prevention – All

Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD):

Prefers consistency and predictability. May experience anxiety or confusion when faced with sudden changes, inconsistent layouts, or ambiguous elements.

WCAG Quotes

“Tell me it’s pouring rain, not an animal parade!”

Clear words for clear skies ahead.”

Neurodiversity

Understandable – WCAG 3.1.3 - Unusual Words



The idiomatic expression “it’s raining cats and dogs,” which is used to describe very heavy rain, might be confusing or misleading for those with autism spectrum disorders (ASD) or others who tend to interpret language more literally.

How Autism (ASD) affects user interactions

Prefers structure and predictability; struggles with ambiguity.

Inconsistent layouts cause stress

Sudden UI changes or unpredictable navigation increase anxiety.

Sensory overload from visuals

Bright colors, animations, and flashing elements can be overwhelming.

Metaphors cause confusion

Abstract or non-literal language makes instructions harder to understand.

A person with Autism (ASD) wants:

Predictable, structured interfaces that minimize sensory overload.

Consistent layouts

Predictable navigation reduces anxiety and improves usability.

WCAG 3.2.3
Consistent Navigation

Minimal animations and sounds

Reducing motion effects prevents overstimulation.

WCAG 2.3.3
Animation from Interactions

Clear, literal language

Avoiding jargon improves comprehension.

WCAG 3.1.5
Reading Level

Customizable settings

Allows users to control contrast, font size, and layout.

WCAG 1.4.8
Visual Presentation

Dyslexia

Struggles with reading, spelling, and text-heavy content. May experience difficulty with dense paragraphs, poor typography, or lack of assistive options, leading to slower processing and increased cognitive effort.

WCAG Quotes

“I asked for readable text, not a jigsaw puzzle of fonts and spacing!”

Disability: Dyslexia

Distinguishable - 1.4.8:Visual Presentation



It's always hard to find anything in a cluttered layout with multiple fonts and tight spacing.

How Dyslexia affects user interactions

Struggles with reading, dense text, and complex layouts.

Hard to process large text blocks

Walls of text slow down reading and increase cognitive effort.

Poor typography affects readability

Small fonts, low contrast, and tight spacing make words harder to distinguish.

Confusing instructions increase errors

Ambiguous wording and complex forms make completing tasks challenging.

A person with Dyslexia wants:

Text that is easy to read, process, and understand.

Readable fonts and spacing

Dyslexia-friendly fonts and spacing improve legibility.

WCAG 1.4.12
Text Spacing

Text-to-speech options

Audio support helps users process information.

WCAG 1.2.1
Audio-only and Video-only

Simplified content structure

Breaking text into short paragraphs and bullet points aids comprehension.

WCAG 2.4.10
Section Headings

Error-tolerant input fields

Spellcheck and autocorrect reduce frustration in form entries.

WCAG 3.3.3
Error Suggestion

Dyspraxia

MP: Affects motor coordination and fine motor skills, making precise interactions challenging. May struggle with complex gestures, small touch targets, or time-sensitive actions, leading to frustration and slower task completion.

WCAG Quotes

“If clicking is a game, let’s not make it a game of precision. A generous target size welcomes more players.”

Neurodivergent condition: Dyspraxia
Input Modalities - WCAG 2.5.5 – Target Size



A close-up image shows a hand pressing large, luminous buttons on a game console, each glowing with vibrant colors, symbolizing fun and interaction.

How Dyspraxia affects user interactions

Struggles with fine motor skills and complex gestures.

Small touch targets are hard to tap

Buttons and links that require precision can cause frustration.

Gesture-based actions are difficult

Drag-and-drop or multi-finger gestures may be hard to perform.

Time-sensitive interactions cause stress

Short response windows make completing tasks harder.

A person with Dyspraxia wants:

Easier navigation and interaction with less fine motor precision needed.

Larger touch targets

Big buttons and well-spaced elements reduce mis-clicks.

WCAG 2.5.5
Target Size

Keyboard shortcuts

Alternative navigation methods improve usability.

WCAG 2.1.4
Character Key Shortcuts

Simplified gestures

Avoiding complex drag-and-drop and combo-box interactions.

WCAG 2.5.1
Pointer Gestures

Adjustable timeouts

Allows more time to complete actions.

WCAG 2.2.1
Timing Adjustable

Dyscalculia

Affects numerical processing and mathematical understanding. May struggle with calculations, number-based tasks, and complex data formats, leading to difficulties in forms, financial transactions, and time management.

WCAG Quotes

***Contextual help? Yes, please!
It's like reading a recipe while
cooking rather than having to guess
the ingredients.***

Neuro-diverse perception: all
Input Assistance – WCAG 3.3.5 - Help



This image highlights the importance of contextual help, like clearly labeled spices or step-by-step recipes, which can empower individuals with cognitive challenges to navigate daily tasks more independently and confidently.

How Dyscalculia affects user interactions

Struggles with numbers, calculations, and time-based tasks.

Math-heavy tasks cause confusion

Calculators, data entry, and number fields can be overwhelming.

Time management is challenging

Reading clocks, understanding time zones, or estimating durations is difficult.

Financial transactions cause stress

Budgeting, forms with fees, or pricing breakdowns may be confusing.

A person with Dyscalculia wants:

Less reliance on numbers and better visual explanations.

Alternative formats for numbers

Graphs and visual breakdowns help comprehension.

WCAG 1.3.1
Info and Relationships

Auto calculations

Reduces manual number processing in forms.

WCAG 3.3.2
Labels or Instructions

Consistent date and time format

Avoids confusion with different numerical representations.

WCAG 3.2.4
Consistent Identification

Step-by-step math guidance

Tooltips and hints help users complete calculations.

WCAG 3.3.5
Help

Anxiety

Heightens sensitivity to uncertainty, pressure, and overwhelming choices. May struggle with time-limited tasks, unclear navigation, or high-stakes interactions, leading to stress, hesitation, and task avoidance.

WCAG Quotes

“Friendly and optimistic messages when I make mistakes it helps me feeling like a child with nothing to worry about”

Neurodiverse perception: Anxiety

Input Assistance – WCAG 3.3.3 – Error Suggestion



A vibrant digital artwork features a young girl leaning against a book, her face enveloped in a burst of colorful, paint-like splashes that blend seamlessly into her skin, portraying a sense of wonder and creativity.

How Anxiety affects user interactions

Sensitive to uncertainty, pressure, and overwhelming choices.

**Unclear navigation
increases stress**

Hidden actions or vague UI elements make users hesitant to proceed.

**Time-limited tasks cause
panic**

Countdown timers and session expirations create unnecessary urgency.

**Too many choices cause
paralysis**

Overwhelming options without guidance make decision-making difficult.

A person with Anxiety wants:

Clear, stress-free interactions with control over pacing.

Predictable workflows

Clear navigation reduces uncertainty and hesitation.

WCAG 3.2.3
Consistent Navigation

No forced time limits

Allows users to control pacing and prevents stress.

WCAG 2.2.1
Timing Adjustable

Reassuring feedback

Friendly error messages reduce panic.

WCAG 3.3.3
Error Suggestion

Low-pressure decision-making

Undo options and saving progress ease hesitation.

WCAG 3.3.6
Error Prevention – All

Depression

Affects motivation, focus, and cognitive processing, making task completion challenging. May struggle with overwhelming interfaces, lack of encouragement, or high-effort interactions, leading to fatigue and disengagement.

WCAG Quotes

“Dark mode isn’t just easier on the eyes; it’s soothing for the soul.”

Neurodiverse perception: Depression
Distinguishable – WCAG 1.4.8 – Visual Presentation



A person enjoys their digital workspace, glowing with purple and pink city lights. Their joy in this modern, tech-savvy environment is palpable, embodying the positive side of technology.

How Depression affects user interactions

Affects motivation, focus, and cognitive effort.

Low energy affects task completion

High-effort actions may feel exhausting or overwhelming.

Minimal feedback causes disengagement

Lack of encouragement or progress indicators makes users lose interest.

Complex workflows feel unmanageable

Too many steps or unclear paths make users more likely to give up.

A person with Depression wants:

Low-effort, engaging experiences that encourage progress.

Minimal steps per task

Reducing effort required prevents task abandonment.

WCAG 2.4.6
Headings and Labels

Encouraging feedback

Progress indicators help maintain motivation.

WCAG 3.3.3
Error Suggestion

Flexible deadlines

More time to complete tasks reduces stress.

WCAG 2.2.1
Timing Adjustable

Dark mode and customization

Reduces eye strain and improves comfort.

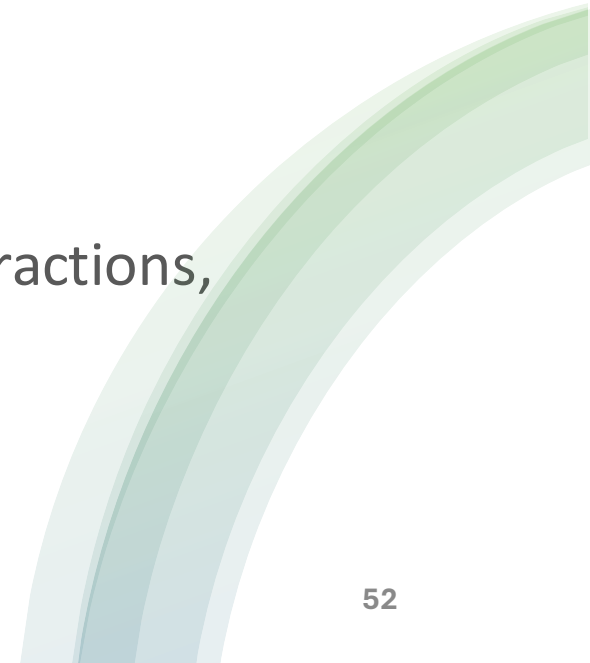
WCAG 1.4.8
Visual Presentation



Takeaway:

At some point in life, we all encounter moments when we need information presented differently.

Whether it's due to stress, grief, exhaustion, or environmental distractions, our ability to process information fluctuates.





Attend our next session:

Creating Accessible Design Systems

3:20pm – Orange County 2



Cognitive and Learning Disabilities
Accessibility Task Force (COGA)

W3C's initiative on cognitive and learning disabilities.

bit.ly/w3c-coga



Designing for Neurodiversity

Neurodiversity Design System

neurodiversity.design



Designing for Neurodiversity

Practical Checklist for UX Designers:

bit.ly/ux-neurodiversity

